

Introduction

In this assignment, I will analyze why balancing is critical to maintain tension between deception and discovery while ensuring the engagement of the player. Below, I focus on three balancing aspects using Jesse Schell's lenses.

1.Head vs Hands

Question: Does the game rely more on the mental reasoning or on the physical skills? Is this balance appropriate?

1) Echoes of the Heart is an entirely "Head-Based" game which relies on the critical thinking, the emotional intelligence and the strategic deception of the player.

2) The game does not require hand-eye coordination, physical skills or reaction time. This fits with the intended audience's interest, which is likely interested in thoughtful and reflective gameplay.

3) The absence of the hands is intentional and aligns with the game's focus on sensemaking and ethical reflection.

Example: This pace allows the players to read, analyze and decide without time pressure, emphasizing on knowledge engagement over physical speed.

2.Simple vs Complex

Question: Is the complexity of the game design appropriate for the intended experience? Does it enhance or overwhelm the player?

1) The main mechanic of the game (email choice and credibility) is simple because the players choose a response from pre-written options.

2) However, the complexity is subjective and comes from the interpretation of the psychological theories and ethical dilemmas.

3) The balance focuses on making the complexity optional: Some players who want to focus on the theory and analyze it can do so, while other players can play based on their intuition.

4) The interface should remain simple with limited options so the players can focus on the narrative point of the game rather than the complex mechanics.

Example: Keep the UI minimal and offer optional "insights" or reference notes for the players who want to understand deeper psychological theories while avoiding overwhelming other players.

3.Challenge vs Success

Question: Does the game balance player challenge with the sense of accomplishment?

1) Since the core mechanism involves around detecting key discussion points and matching the tone of the other psychologist, the difficulty must scale appropriately.

2) The early email choices should be more easy, while the later emails should introduce more ethical dilemmas or ambiguous responses.

3) The game must reward the players with narrative feedback (for example, reactions from the psychologist) which will reflect their success or failure.

4) Completing the game without getting detected rewards the player with a book which will combine the emails and the player's responses, providing a concrete accomplishment.

Example: Increase tension by gradually introducing more unclear responses in the last emails, but counterbalance this by providing more specific consequences (for example some changes in the psychologist's responses if the player slips)